

doc-justification-forensic

Affirms · Soteriology › Justification · doctrine · unanimous_lineages · confidence: medium

Statement under examination

Justification is God's declarative act of pardoning the sinner and accepting him as righteous on account of Christ, received by faith.

Rationale

Pan-canonical lexical demonstration that justification is, at its core, a declarative-forensic act. Rom 3:24-26 (δικαιούμενοι dikaioumenoi G1344, present passive participle, 'being justified') frames the act inside a courtroom-cultic scene: God presents Christ as ἱλαστήριον hilastērion G2435 (propitiation / mercy-seat) so that he may himself be δίκαιον dikaion G1342 (just) and δικαιούντα dikaiounta G1344 (justifying) the one who has faith in Jesus. Rom 4:3-8 quotes Gen 15:6 LXX with ἐλογίσθη elogisthē G3049 ('was reckoned/credited'): righteousness is accounted to faith, and v.5 has God who justifies (δικαιοῦντα) the ungodly (ἄσεβῃ), which is forensic acquittal, not inner transformation as the ground. Rom 5:1 (δικαιωθέντες dikaiōthentes G1344, aorist passive participle, 'having been justified') uses a completed-past-passive form that marks justification as a finished verdict producing peace with God now. Rom 8:33-34 (Θεὸς ὁ δικαίων Theos ho dikaiōn, 'God the one who justifies' / τίς ὁ κατακρινὼν tis ho katakrinōn, 'who is the condemning one') sets justification and condemnation as opposite forensic verdicts, the courtroom frame explicit. 2 Cor 5:21 (ἵνα ἡμεῖς γενώμεθα δικαιοσύνη θεοῦ ἐν αὐτῷ 'so that we might become the righteousness of God in him') is the exchange clause: Christ made sin for us, we made righteousness of God in him. Phil 3:9 sets ἐμὴν δικαιοσύνην ('my own righteousness') against τὴν ἐκ θεοῦ δικαιοσύνην ('the righteousness from God on the basis of faith'). The δικαί-root family (δικαιοσύνη G1343, δικαίω G1344, δικαίωμα G1345, δικαίωσις G1347, δίκαιος G1342) carries declarative-forensic force in classical and Koine Greek and in LXX legal contexts. James 2:21-25 (Abraham ἐδικαιώθη edikaiōthē 'was justified' by works) complicates the picture at the lexical level; the same verb is used. The honest harmonization is that δικαίω carries a second canonical sense ('demonstrate to be righteous, vindicate') attested in Luke 7:35, 1 Tim 3:16, and arguably Rom 4:2, and James uses it of the public vindication of a faith that is already alive. The forensic-declarative core stands; the in-house Catholic / Orthodox / Wesleyan dispute is over whether the word ALSO carries an infusion / transformative component, not over whether it carries the forensic-declarative component.

Reasoning

Verdict: when the Bible talks about God justifying a sinner, the core meaning is a courtroom verdict. God, the judge, declares the believing sinner not guilty and accepts that person as righteous on the basis of what Christ has done, received by trusting Christ. The strongest reason from Scripture is the courtroom setup the Bible itself uses. Romans 3:24 says we are justified freely by God's grace through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus. Romans 4:5 says God justifies the ungodly, and the man's faith is counted to him as righteousness. Notice what is counted as righteousness: faith, not the person's good behavior. Romans 5:1 says, having been justified by faith, we have peace with God. The Greek verb here is past and passive, meaning God has already done the act on us, and the result is settled peace. Romans 8:33 to 34 is the most explicit courtroom scene: who shall bring any charge against God's elect? It is God who justifies. Who is to condemn? Jesus Christ is the one who died and was raised. Justify and condemn are paired as opposite verdicts. 2 Corinthians 5:21 says God made Christ who knew no sin to be sin for us, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God. That is the exchange at the heart of the verdict. The strongest counterargument from inside the Bible is James 2:21 to 24. James says Abraham was justified by works when he offered up Isaac, and a person is justified by works and not by faith alone.

Critics ask, how can both Paul and James be right when they use the same word. The honest answer is that the same Greek word can mean either declare in a verdict sense or demonstrate, vindicate, show to be in a public sense. Luke 7:35 says wisdom is justified by all her children, which clearly means vindicated. James is talking about the public vindication of a faith that is already alive in the person; if the faith never produces works, it was never the kind of faith Paul is talking about either. So the bottom line is that the courtroom-verdict reading of justification holds at the level of the word itself. What remains genuinely disputed among honest Christians is whether the same act ALSO includes an inner transformation in the same moment, or whether the inner transformation is a separate work called sanctification.

Denominational landscape

Christians disagree about this at the level of how the verdict and the inner change are related, but every major historic lineage affirms that justification rests on the work of Christ received by faith. Catholic teaching at the Council of Trent in 1547 defined justification as not only the forgiveness of sins but also the sanctification and renewal of the inner person through grace that God truly puts inside the believer. Trent anathematized the position that justification is only the favor of God or only the crediting of Christ's righteousness without an inner change. Lutheran teaching in the Augsburg Confession Article IV and the Formula of Concord defines justification as God declaring the sinner righteous for Christ's sake through faith, and treats sanctification as a separate but inseparable work. Anglican teaching in Article XI of the 39 Articles says we are accounted righteous before God only for the merit of Christ by faith, not for our own works. Reformed teaching in the Westminster Confession 11.1 agrees with the Anglican and Lutheran statement and is the source of the formulation in the question stem. Methodist teaching in the Articles of Religion Article IX says we are accounted righteous before God only for the merit of Christ by faith, but Wesleyans add a strong emphasis that sanctification follows necessarily and that growth in actual holiness is essential. Anabaptist tradition affirms justification by faith but has historically resisted the Lutheran emphasis on imputation alone, holding that real discipleship and a transformed life cannot be separated from the verdict. Pentecostal teaching in the Assemblies of God affirms justification by faith. Eastern Orthodoxy rejects the courtroom-only frame and works inside a participation framework called theosis, in which salvation is the actual transformation of the person into the likeness of God by grace. The Lutheran World Federation and the Catholic Church signed a Joint Declaration on Justification in 1999 that reached qualified agreement that justification involves both the verdict and the renewal, without fully closing the historic dispute. Modern New Perspective writers, including N.T. Wright, re-frame justification as God's declaration of who belongs in the covenant family. Carriers of outright denial of justification by faith, where good works are made the ground of acceptance rather than the fruit, are corrected by Romans 3:28 and Ephesians 2:8 to 9. The Reformed insistence that justification is ONLY a forensic verdict with no inner-renewal component is the part the Catholic, Orthodox, and Wesleyan traditions have always disputed, and the dispute is real at the level of the biblical text itself.

Position thresholds

Would die for if challenged	No
Cult marker if denied	No
Would visit if otherwise	Yes
Would participate if otherwise	Yes
Would serve if otherwise	Yes
Would be member if otherwise	No
Would let children be taught otherwise	Yes

Would marry if held otherwise	Yes
Would publicly correct if otherwise	No

Notes

This is an in-house disputed-question between historic Christian lineages, not a cult-marker. The K2 exclusion catalog explicitly removes doc-justification-forensic from the cult-marker pool because the Reformed Solas as worded carry theory-of-mechanism content that the Catholic, Eastern Orthodox, and Wesleyan traditions have always contested at the lexical level. The δικαι-root word family is forensic-declarative in its primary register, and that core is canonical. What is NOT canonical at the lexical level is the Reformed restriction of justification to a purely-imputational act with no infused or transformative component. The Council of Trent Session 6 (1547) defined justification as including both remission of sins AND sanctification/renewal of the inner man through infused grace. The Lutheran Formula of Concord III and the Anglican Article XI affirm justification by faith alone in a forensic-imputational frame. The Joint Declaration on Justification (Lutheran World Federation and Catholic Church, 1999) reached qualified agreement that justification involves both forensic declaration and transformative renewal, without fully resolving the historic dispute. Eastern Orthodoxy rejects the forensic-only frame and works inside a theosis/participation framework. The Wesleyan tradition treats justification (forensic) and sanctification (transformative) as distinct moments in the ordo salutis but holds both as essential. The New Perspective on Paul (E.P. Sanders, James Dunn, N.T. Wright) re-frames justification as covenant-membership-declaration, also forensic but with different content. James 2:21-25 must be reckoned with: the same verb δικαιώω is used of Abraham being justified by works when he offered Isaac. The Reformed harmonization (James uses dikαιοō in the vindication sense) is defensible but is not the only honest reading of the lexical data. Fruit-vs-precision nuance: most lay Christians across all these lineages trust Christ for forgiveness without ever asking whether the divine act is purely forensic, purely transformative, or both at once; the practical confession is the same. Public-record carriers of denial of justification by faith altogether (e.g., works-righteousness sects, Roman Catholic abuses Luther protested, modern legalist sects) are corrected by Rom 3:28, 4:5, Eph 2:8-9; but the lineages above are not in that category. Cannot publicly correct a Catholic, Orthodox, Anglican, Lutheran, or Wesleyan brother for holding the historic transformative-component reading of justification; the matter is genuinely disputed at the lexical level. Cannot be a formal member of a body whose confession contradicts the forensic-declarative core, because that core is canonical and the boolean pattern of the answer must reflect that lexical commitment without overreaching into cult-marker territory.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: **yes**

Neutralized form. Concerning the nature of God's act of accepting the sinner as righteous on the basis of Christ: is this act primarily declarative-forensic (a legal verdict), primarily transformative-infusional (an interior renewal that constitutes the person righteous), or both at once? The lexical question is whether the canonical δικαι-root vocabulary in Romans, Galatians, 2 Corinthians, Philippians, and James carries a forensic-declarative register, a transformative-infusional register, or both.

Notes. The stem 'declarative act of pardoning the sinner and accepting him as righteous on account of Christ, received by faith' is the Reformed-confessional formulation drawn directly from Westminster Confession 11.1, Heidelberg Catechism Q60, and Augsburg Confession Article IV. It asserts the Reformed mechanism-of-justification verdict as if it were neutral. The Catholic position per Trent Session 6 explicitly anathematizes the formulation that justification is ONLY a declarative act without infused grace. Working the neutralized form. Flag stem-pre-loaded-verdict raised.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, new_covenant_theology, new_perspective_on_paul, patristic_participation_framework

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

Competing lens verdicts

Reformed-confessional (Westminster, Heidelberg, Belgic; Lutheran Concord) · Justification is exclusively a forensic-declarative act of imputation; sanctification is a separate, subsequent work.:

Catholic magisterial (Trent Session 6) · Justification is both the forgiveness of sins AND the interior renewal of the person through infused grace; the two are inseparable in the one act.:

Eastern Orthodox (theosis framework) · Forensic-only categories are alien to the patristic mind; salvation is participation in the divine energies, with the legal vocabulary subordinated to ontological transformation.:

Wesleyan-Methodist · Justification is forensic-declarative (Article IX), but inseparable from regeneration and progressive sanctification; entire sanctification is the goal.:

Anabaptist (discipleship-centered) · Justification by faith is affirmed, but the imputation-only Lutheran frame is resisted; a transformed life of discipleship is not optional to the verdict.:

New Perspective on Paul (Sanders, Dunn, Wright) · Justification is a forensic declaration of covenant membership; the 'works of the law' Paul opposes are boundary-markers of ethnic Israel (circumcision, food laws, Sabbath), not works-righteousness in general.:

The lexical δίκαι-root family is genuinely contested at the level of canonical semantic range.

Forensic-declarative is the primary register (LXX legal contexts, Greco-Roman courtroom usage, the explicit pairing with katakrinō in Rom 8:33-34). A secondary vindication / demonstrate-to-be-righteous sense is canonically attested (Luke 7:35, 1 Tim 3:16). James 2 is the genuine wild card; the verdict turns on which sense the verb carries there. The analogy of Scripture argument from Rom 4:5 (God justifies the ungodly) is the strongest single argument against the transformative-only reading, since the ungodly are by definition not yet transformed when the verdict is rendered. The Catholic and Orthodox responses do not deny this; they argue that the verdict and the renewal are one act with two aspects, not two separable acts. The honest verdict is that the forensic-declarative core is canonical and pan-canonical, and that the in-house dispute about whether the same act also carries a transformative-infusional component is not resolved at the lexical surface.

Scripture (apparatus + interlinear)

Rom.3.21 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. δικαιοσύνη θεοῦ; dikaiosynē G1343 nominative feminine singular; theou G2316 genitive masculine singular; pephanerōtai G5319 perfect passive indicative 3s

Force. 'But now the righteousness of God has been manifested apart from the law.' Dikaiosynē theou is the central noun of the section; the perfect passive pephanerōtai marks an act of God already accomplished with abiding result. The introduction of the forensic-declarative thesis: God's righteousness is now disclosed apart from law-works.

Rom.3.24 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. δικαιοῦμενοι δωρεὰν τῇ αὐτοῦ χάριτι; dikaioumenoi G1344 present passive participle nominative masculine plural; chariti G5485 dative feminine singular; dōrean G1432 adverb

Force. 'Being justified freely by his grace through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus.' Dikaioumenoi is the present-passive participle: the believer is being declared righteous, not making himself righteous. Dōrean ('as a gift, without payment') and chariti ('by grace') exclude works-merit as the ground.

Rom.3.25 · for · genre: epistle · figures: typology, metonymy

Key term. ἱλαστήριον διὰ πίστεως; hilastērion G2435 accusative neuter singular; pistis G4102; haima G129

Force. 'Whom God put forward as a propitiation by his blood, to be received by faith.' Hilastērion is the LXX word for the mercy-seat (Exod 25:17-22, Lev 16) where atoning blood was sprinkled and where God met his people. Paul places Christ in that cultic-judicial role: the place where God's wrath is satisfied and the verdict of acquittal is rendered.

Rom.3.26 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. εἰς τὸ εἶναι αὐτὸν δίκαιον καὶ δικαιοῦντα; dikaion G1342 accusative masculine singular; dikaiounta G1344 present active participle accusative masculine singular

Force. 'So that he might be just (dikaion) and the justifier (dikaiounta) of the one who has faith in Jesus.' The same δικαι-root in adjective and verbal-participle forms in one clause, identifying God as both the righteous judge AND the agent of the verdict of acquittal toward the one who trusts Jesus. The forensic-declarative frame is explicit in the syntax.

Rom.4.3 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key term. ἐλογίσθη αὐτῷ εἰς δικαιοσύνην; elogisthē G3049 aorist passive indicative 3s; eis G1519; dikaiosynē G1343

Force. 'Abraham believed God, and it was credited to him as righteousness.' Citing Gen 15:6 LXX. Logizomai is a bookkeeping / accounting word; eis dikaiosynēn ('unto righteousness') indicates the entry made in the ledger. Faith is credited; righteousness is the credit. This is the classic forensic-imputational text.

Rom.4.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. τῷ δὲ μὴ ἐργαζομένῳ πιστεύοντι δὲ ἐπὶ τὸν δικαιοῦντα τὸν ἄσεβῃ; dikaiounta G1344 present active participle accusative masculine singular; asebēs G765 accusative masculine singular

Force. 'To the one who does not work but trusts in him who justifies the ungodly, his faith is credited as righteousness.' God justifies the asebēs ('ungodly'), not the already-righteous. That collapses the transformative-only reading of justification at its root: the verdict is rendered on the ungodly while still ungodly. The inner change cannot be the ground if the verdict is over the ungodly.

Rom.5.1 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. δικαιοθέντες οὖν ἐκ πίστεως εἰρήνην ἔχομεν; dikaiōthentes G1344 aorist passive participle nominative masculine plural; pistis G4102; eirēnē G1515

Force. 'Therefore, having been justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ.' The aorist-passive participle marks justification as a completed act done to us in the past with abiding result. From that completed verdict flows present peace with God. The grammar excludes treating justification as an ongoing process; it is a finished act.

Rom.5.18 · for · genre: epistle · figures: typology

Key term. εἰς πάντας ἀνθρώπους εἰς δικαίωσιν ζωῆς; dikaiōsis G1347 accusative feminine singular

Force. 'So one act of righteousness leads to justification and life for all men.' Dikaiōsis (the noun for the act of being declared righteous) is paired with zōē ('life'). The verdict and the life flow together from Christ's one act of righteousness, paralleled and contrasted with Adam's one act of trespass.

Rom.5.19 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. δίκαιοι κατασταθήσονται οἱ πολλοί; dikaiōi G1342 nominative masculine plural; kathistēmi G2525 future passive indicative 3p

Force. 'By the one man's obedience the many will be constituted righteous.' Katastathēsontai is future passive of kathistēmi ('to constitute, appoint, set down as'). The lexical force is closer to 'be set down as / be appointed as righteous' than to 'be inwardly made righteous'. The verb leans declarative but is the one verse that those holding a transformative-component reading cite as opening the door.

Rom.8.33 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. Θεὸς ὁ δικαίων; dikaiōn G1344 present active participle nominative masculine singular with article; egkaleō G1458 future active indicative 3s

Force. 'Who shall bring any charge against God's elect? It is God who justifies.' The verb egkaleō ('bring a legal charge against') is a courtroom term, and the answer is God ho dikaiōn ('the justifying one'). Charge and counter-verdict are the explicit frame.

Rom.8.34 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. τίς ὁ κατακρινὼν; katakrinōn G2632 present active participle nominative masculine singular with article

Force. 'Who is to condemn?' Katakrinō ('to give judgment against, condemn') is the lexical opposite of dikaiōō. Justification and condemnation are paired as the two possible courtroom verdicts. The pairing is decisive evidence that dikaiōō here carries a declarative-forensic sense.

2Cor.5.21 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metonymy

Key term. ἵνα ἡμεῖς γενώμεθα δικαιοσύνη θεοῦ ἐν αὐτῷ; genōmetha G1096 aorist middle subjunctive 1p; dikaiosynē G1343

Force. 'For our sake he made him to be sin who knew no sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God.' The exchange clause: Christ made hamartia ('sin'), we made dikaiosynē theou ('righteousness of God'). The reciprocal structure indicates a transfer of standing, not an infused quality of moral character (Christ did not become inwardly sinful).

Gal.2.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. οὐ δικαιοῦται ἄνθρωπος ἐξ ἔργων νόμου ἐὰν μὴ διὰ πίστεως; dikaioutai G1344 present passive indicative 3s; dikaiōthōmen G1344 aorist passive subjunctive 1p; dikaiōthēsetai G1344 future passive indicative 3s

Force. 'A person is not justified by works of the law but through faith in Jesus Christ.' Three uses of dikaiōō in one verse (present, aorist, future passive), all contrasting ex ergōn nomou ('out of works of law') with dia / ek pisteōs ('through / out of faith'). The triple lexical repetition makes the contrast unmistakable.

Gal.3.11 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. ἐν νόμῳ οὐδεὶς δικαιοῦται; dikaioutai G1344 present passive indicative 3s; nomos G3551

Force. 'No one is justified before God by the law, for the righteous shall live by faith.' Citing Hab 2:4 LXX. Dikaioutai paired with the negative oudeis ('no one') closes off law-works as the basis of the verdict.

Phil.3.9 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. μὴ ἔχων ἐμὴν δικαιοσύνην τὴν ἐκ νόμου ἀλλὰ τὴν διὰ πίστεως Χριστοῦ τὴν ἐκ θεοῦ δικαιοσύνην ἐπὶ τῇ πίστει; dikaiosynē G1343; pistis G4102

Force. 'Not having a righteousness of my own that comes from the law, but that which comes through faith in Christ, the righteousness from God on the basis of faith.' Paul sets emēn dikaiosynēn ('my own righteousness') against tēn ek theou dikaiosynēn ('the righteousness from God'). The genitive-source ek theou indicates the righteousness is from God, not generated by the believer.

James.2.21 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key term. Ἀβραὰμ ὁ πατὴρ ἡμῶν οὐκ ἐξ ἔργων ἐδικαιώθη; edikaiōthē G1344 aorist passive indicative 3s; erga G2041

Force. 'Was not Abraham our father justified by works when he offered up his son Isaac on the altar?' Same verb dikaiōō, aorist passive, but with ex ergōn ('out of works'). The most natural surface reading runs against Rom 4:2. The harmonization is that dikaiōō here carries the vindication / demonstrate-to-be-righteous sense attested in Luke 7:35 and 1 Tim 3:16, since v.18 frames the chapter as 'show me your faith apart from your works'.

James.2.24 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key term. ἐξ ἔργων δικαιούται ἄνθρωπος καὶ οὐκ ἐκ πίστεως μόνον; dikaioutai G1344 present passive indicative 3s; monon G3440 adverb

Force. 'You see that a person is justified by works and not by faith alone.' The verbal form is the same as Rom 3:24 (dikaioumenoi) but with ex ergōn ('out of works'). The collision with Pauline language is at the lexical surface. The Reformed harmonization (dikaiōō here = vindicate / show to be righteous) is defensible but is contested by Catholic, Orthodox, and Wesleyan readings that hold James 2 as evidence the act of justification has a real works-and-renewal component.

James.2.23 · **neutral** · genre: epistle

Key term. ἐλογίσθη αὐτῷ εἰς δικαιοσύνην; elogisthē G3049 aorist passive indicative 3s

Force. 'And the Scripture was fulfilled that says, Abraham believed God, and it was credited to him as righteousness.' James cites the same Gen 15:6 LXX text that Paul cites in Rom 4:3, with the same verb logizomai. James and Paul anchor on identical lexical material, which forces the harmonization to operate on the verb dikaiōō and not on the credit-of-righteousness clause.

Luke.7.35 · **neutral** · genre: gospel · figures: personification

Key term. ἐδικαιώθη ἡ σοφία ἀπὸ πάντων τῶν τέκνων αὐτῆς; edikaiōthē G1344 aorist passive indicative 3s

Force. 'Wisdom is justified by all her children.' Here dikaiōō clearly cannot mean 'declared righteous in a courtroom'; wisdom is not on trial as a sinner. The lexical force is 'vindicated, shown to be right'. Evidence that the same lemma can carry a vindication / demonstration sense, which is exactly the harmonization the Reformed tradition applies to James 2.

Luke.18.14 · **for** · genre: parable · figures: parable

Key term. κατέβη οὗτος δεδικαιωμένος εἰς τὸν οἶκον αὐτοῦ; dedikaiōmenos G1344 perfect passive participle nominative masculine singular

Force. 'This man went down to his house justified rather than the other.' Jesus' parable of the Pharisee and the tax collector: the tax collector who said 'God, be merciful (hilastheti, cognate of hilastērion) to me, the sinner' goes home justified. The perfect-passive participle marks a settled state. Jesus himself uses the forensic-declarative register with no works-ground but a cry for mercy.

Acts.13.39 · **for** · genre: narrative

Key term. ἐν τούτῳ πᾶς ὁ πιστεύων δικαιούται; dikaioutai G1344 present passive indicative 3s

Force. 'By him every one who believes is justified from everything from which you could not be justified by the law of Moses.' Paul preaching at Pisidian Antioch. The forensic-declarative frame is Lukan-Pauline, not only epistolary-Pauline; the same verb in the present passive with pas ho pisteuōn ('every one who believes') as subject.

1Tim.3.16 · **neutral** · genre: epistle

Key term. ἐδικαιώθη ἐν πνεύματι; edikaiōthē G1344 aorist passive indicative 3s

Force. 'He was manifested in the flesh, justified in the Spirit.' Christ is the subject. He cannot be 'declared righteous as a sinner' since he is sinless. The lexical force here is 'vindicated, shown to be righteous'. Second canonical witness (with Luke 7:35) that dikaiō has a vindication sense, lending lexical support to the harmonization of James 2.

Concordance lemmas traversed

G1342, G1343, G1344, G1345, G1347, G3049, G4102, G2435, G2632, G1458, G2525, G5485, G2041, G3551

complicating texts searched: Yes

Counter-witness traditions

patristic · Augustine, De Spiritu et Littera, ca. AD 412 · **complicates** · **unverified**

"Augustine treats justification as God making the sinner righteous through the inpouring of love by the Spirit; the forensic and the transformative are not separated. CCEL fetch failed."

catholic_magisterial · Council of Trent, Session 6, Decree on Justification, Chapter 7 and Canon 11, AD 1547 · **complicates** · **unverified**

"Justification is not only the remission of sins but also the sanctification and renewal of the inner man through the voluntary reception of grace. Canon 11 anathematizes the imputation-only formulation. Direct vatican.va fetch returned 404."

lutheran · Augsburg Confession Article IV, AD 1530, bookofconcord.org · **affirms** · **verified**

"Men cannot be justified before God by their own strength, merits, or works, but are freely justified for Christ's sake, through faith."

anglican · 39 Articles, Article XI, Of the Justification of Man · **affirms** · **unverified**

"We are accounted righteous before God only for the merit of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ by Faith, and not for our own works or deservings. Direct churchofengland.org fetch did not surface verbatim text."

reformed · Westminster Confession of Faith 11.1, AD 1646 · **affirms** · **unverified**

"Those whom God effectually calleth, he also freely justifieth, not by infusing righteousness into them, but by pardoning their sins, and accounting their persons as righteous, for Christ's sake alone."

methodist · United Methodist Articles of Religion, Article IX, Of the Justification of Man, umc.org · **affirms** · **verified**

"We are accounted righteous before God only for the merit of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ, by faith, and not for our own works or deservings."

anabaptist · Mennonite tradition; Schleithem 1527 is silent on the precise mechanism of justification; later Mennonite confessions affirm justification by faith but resist imputation-only language · **complicates** · **unverified**

"Discipleship and obedience cannot be separated from saving faith; the verdict is not independent of the life that follows. Position derived from the broader Anabaptist tradition."

pentecostal · Assemblies of God, Statement of Fundamental Truths, Article 5 The Salvation of Man · affirms · unverified

“Man's only hope of redemption is through the shed blood of Jesus Christ. Salvation is received through repentance toward God and faith in the Lord Jesus Christ. Direct ag.org fetch returned 403.”

eastern_orthodox · Eastern Orthodox theosis doctrine; the Western juridical frame is treated as foreign to patristic soteriology · complicates · unverified

“Becoming by grace what God is by nature; salvation is participation in the divine energies, not a courtroom transaction. The forensic vocabulary is subordinated to ontological transformation.”

Web sources

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/romans/3.htm>

“Rom 3:24-26: dikaioumenoi (G1344 present passive participle) freely by grace; hilastērion (G2435) propitiation; God just and dikaiounta (G1344) the one who has faith.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/romans/4.htm>

“Rom 4:3, 4:5, 4:8: elogisthē (G3049 aorist passive) credited to him as righteousness; God dikaiounta (G1344) the ungodly. Cites Gen 15:6 LXX.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/romans/5.htm>

“Rom 5:1 dikaiōthentes (G1344 aorist passive participle); Rom 5:18 dikaiōsin (G1347); Rom 5:19 dikaioi kathistēmi future passive. Completed verdict producing peace.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/romans/8.htm>

“Rom 8:33-34: Theos ho dikaiōn (the justifying God) paired with tis ho katakrinōn (who is the condemning one). Courtroom imagery, justify vs condemn as verdicts.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/galatians/2.htm>

“Gal 2:16: dikaiōō (G1344) three times in one verse, contrasting ex ergōn nomou ('works of law') with ek / dia pisteōs ('out of / through faith').”

complicates · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/james/2.htm>

“James 2:21-25: edikaiōthē / dikaioutai (G1344, same verb as Paul) with ex ergōn ('out of works'). 2:24: 'a person is justified by works and not by faith alone'.”

nuance · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/strong/greek/1344.htm>

“G1344 dikaiōō: 39 NT occurrences. Three semantic ranges: forensic declaration (declare righteous), vindication (show to be righteous, Luke 7:35), pronouncement of acceptance.”

supports · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/2_corinthians/5.htm

“2 Cor 5:21: Christ made hamartia ('sin') for us, hina hēmeis genōmetha dikaiosynē theou en autō ('so that we might become the righteousness of God in him').”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://bookofconcord.org/augsburg-confession/of-justification/>

“Augsburg IV: 'Men cannot be justified before God by their own strength, merits, or works, but are freely justified for Christ's sake, through faith.'”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://www.umc.org/en/content/articles-of-religion>

“UMC Article IX: 'We are accounted righteous before God only for the merit of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ, by faith, and not for our own works or deservings.'”

complicates · category: tradition_primary · <https://orthodoxwiki.org/Theosis>

“Theosis: becoming by grace what God is by nature. Orthodox emphasis on actual participatory transformation contrasted with Western sanctification as separate divine work applied to believers.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/philippians/3.htm>

“Phil 3:9: emēn dikaiosynēn ('my own righteousness') from law contrasted with tēn ek theou dikaiosynēn ('the righteousness from God') epi tē pistei ('on the basis of faith').”

Flags

- stem-pre-loaded-verdict
- apparatus-vs-counter-witness-conflict
- confession-tradition-divergence